

Nokia demonstrates WP7

Nokia demonstrated its first WP7 device code named Sea Ray. It comes with Mango update, an 8MP camera with Carl Zeiss optics and Gorilla Glass

'High profile' on Facebook

Reed Hastings, Chairman and CEO of Netflix has joined Facebook's Board of Directors. Are we expecting a future Facebook with movies on demand?

antennae, while the larger TL-WR1043ND has three. Both routers are built exceptionally well, and feel rugged enough to survive a drop.

The ASUS RT-N16 is a large router that is also quite good looking with its off white colour and is well built to boot. It has 2 USB ports, and a small WPS button that looks like a reset button the rear - not the most intuitive setup for securing your network, but at least the feature is there. The Linksys E2000 is a nice black colour with the top bezel sporting a grey colour. It's as small as the WRT120N and E1000, but feels heavier and better built. It also doesn't heat up as much. It



TPLink TL-MR3420

was the only router in this group to miss out on a USB port. The Dlink DIR-655 looks nice, and reminds us of the TPLink routers, but it isn't as well built.

ASUS has a very nice firmware interface - all the basic menus like the USB media port, bandwidth management and such are segregated. And all the traditional LAN and wireless settings are under advanced settings. Clicking an option opens a drop down style menu with a lot of sub options. The menus are quite intuitive but the help menu with explanations is located underneath. TPLink surprised us with their router interface - perhaps one of the best laid out ones to date. There is a lot of fine-grained control available, but not at the cost of usability and the moment you select an option, a useful

window on the side explains everything you need to know about it. Linksys' interface is the same as we've seen over the past - it's well laid out with a lot of options and looks very professional, but some of the other routers have more newbie-friendly interfaces.

Performance

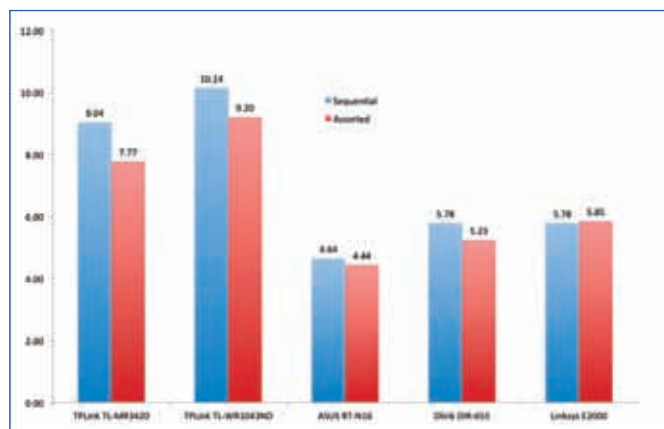
While none of these routers supported dual simultaneous band transfers, or any such tricks to extract maximum bandwidth, the fastest router bar none was in this category. In fact, the second fastest router also made its home here. With speeds of around 3.5 megabytes per second in zone three, the TPLink TL-MR3420 blazed through our tests. In zone one, video playback was flawlessly smooth. Try as we did, we couldn't get a single glitch in video playback. In zone three as well it performed admirably, with a 1.5 second delay between video resuming after a skip. Its sibling the TL-WR1043ND lagged slightly behind, but still comfortably ahead of the others.

The TPLink TL-MR3420 won our Best Performer award for its sterling performance across zones and different tests. If you're looking for the fastest router around, this is surely your best bet. The fact that it has a USB port for 3G data cards and a compact form are bonuses. As it turns out,

this router was also the cheapest in this group, and thus it has an unbeatable bang for buck quotient. It wins our Best Buy award too. If you need a router with a USB port for media sharing, look no further than its slightly costlier sibling, the TL-WR1043ND that performed nearly as well for around 600 bucks more.

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When shopping for a router in the price range, one must remember that you're essentially buying a device that has a few more features that may or may not be useful to you. Media sharing is a given, heck even cheaper routers feature this. Dual simultaneous band transmission becomes a selling point, however, the bandwidth over both frequencies cannot be clubbed. This is only for use with clients of a similar frequency, for example you could set your notebooks adapter to connect to the 2.4 GHz channel, while you stream a video to your other notebook using the 5 GHz channel. A single adapter cannot connect to both networks at the same time, however two different devices can definitely get full bandwidth, since the router has two wireless radios instead of one. This category consisted of 6 devices - one each from ASUS, Belkin, Dlink, Linksys, Netgear and ZyXEL.



Zone 1 transfers

Looks and features

Needless to say some the routers in this category were some of the most feature rich ones we've seen, while others were really funky looking. Take ASUS' RT-N56U - a dual simultaneous band router that is flat with a nice diamond-like texture on the front that causes light reflections on its glossy surface. The router is quite slim, but when viewed from the front looks flat, and the embedded activity LEDs too have a nice sparkling effect going. The Linksys E3000 was by far the largest and sturdiest of the Linksys routers and has a nice dark blue bezel running around the otherwise black body. Dlink's DIR-685 has a heavy-duty metal stand.

It's thick for it has a 2.5-inch notebook drive. This is a really nifty feature since the router



TPLink TL-MR3420

also has 2 USB ports, so it can connect up to three drives. The LCD display on the front is another first, and looks better than the one on the Belkin N1 Vision. Dlink's interface is not the easiest to intuitively understand. Despite very mediocre performance, we still love this router for two reasons: firstly, when we first saw this router a couple of years ago, we figured everyone would jump on to the hard drive-torrent-router band-